

The workflow teardown

A way to turn something you do over and over into something that mostly does itself.
Five steps, and the last one sends you back to the third.

Treat it like a bright new intern who has never worked here. Capable, fast, eager, and completely ignorant of how your office actually runs. Whatever you would have to tell that person is your prompt.

THE FIVE STEPS

- 1 **Name the task**
One sentence. What the job is, and what you want to come out the other end. Do not add detail yet - you are telling it what room you are standing in.
- 2 **Write the context a new employee would need**
The part everyone skips, and the part that decides whether this works. Where the information lives, what the columns are called and in what order, what the values mean, what a normal example looks like. It cannot see your screen and it will not ask.
- 3 **Hand it over as instructions - as a first message, not a finished one**
Every rule, including what to leave alone. Every guardrail, including what it must never do. Then send it, knowing it is wrong somewhere. This is the opening move of a conversation, not a specification you got right.
- 4 **Test it on an example where you already know the answer**
Not a real one. A made-up one, small, where you can count the correct result on your fingers before you run it. If you cannot tell right from wrong, you cannot tell working from broken - and broken usually looks fine.
- 5 **Read the result like an editor, then go back to step three**
Tell it what it got wrong, in plain language, and paste the error if there is one. Then again. The loop **is** the method. Nobody good at this gets it on the first try; they just keep going after it fails.

THREE THINGS THAT ARE TRUE EVERY TIME

Your first message is a draft, and so is your understanding of your own process.

I told it the report would arrive as a spreadsheet attachment. It built me something that read spreadsheet attachments, flawlessly. There were no attachments. It built exactly what I described, and what I described was wrong.

It does not know when it is wrong, and it never sounds like it.

A report had a summary line at the top reading "Total Records: 4." My script read that 4, decided it was a student ID, and went looking for the student named 4. It did not hesitate. Nothing in the output looked wrong.

The thing that breaks it is never the hard part.

Mine looked for unread emails. So if anyone opened one on their phone before the script ran, that student's data was gone - silently, permanently. The code was fine. The assumption underneath it was one I never noticed I had made.

And the rule that sits over all of it: the AI does not need to see a real person to be useful. Give it the shape of your data and an invented example. What comes back is a set of instructions that runs where your data already lives.

The same five steps, inside one prompt

The prompt on your exercise card, cut apart. Nothing here is clever - it is somebody explaining their own job carefully to someone who has never done it.

1 Name the task

I use a Google Sheet to track students who each need to complete a requirement. I want a Google Apps Script that decides who needs a reminder and writes the emails for me.

Two sentences. The situation, then the ask.

2 The context a new employee would need

The sheet has one tab called Roster with these columns in this order: Name, Email, Item needed, Status, Due date, Reminders sent, Last reminder. Row 1 is headers. Status is one of Not started, Started, or Complete. [...]

Here is a sample row so you can see the shape:

Avery Nolan | avery.nolan@example.com | Immunization record | Not started | 2026-08-01 | 0 | (blank)

Column order, what the values mean, one invented row. Skip this and it guesses - confidently.

3 The rules, spelled all the way out

- If Status is Complete, skip the row.
- If the due date has not passed, skip the row.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 0, create a first reminder.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 1 and Last reminder was 7 or more days ago, create a second, firmer reminder. [...]

Every branch, including the ones where the answer is do nothing. The rows you want left alone need a rule too.

3 The guardrails - what it must never do

- Create Gmail drafts. Do not send anything.
- After drafting, increase Reminders sent by one and put today's date in Last reminder.
- Add comments explaining what each section does, because I don't write code.

"Do not send anything" is the line between a mistake and an incident. And telling it who you are changes what comes back more than any wording trick.

4 Test it where you already know the answer

Your practice sheet has eight invented people. Four should get emails. Three should be skipped, and each of the three is skipped for a **different reason**. The answer key is on the card. A script that skips them for the wrong reasons still looks like it worked, and that is the entire lesson.

5 Read it like an editor, then go back to step three

Wrong count? Nothing happened? It tried to send instead of draft? Say so, in plain language, and paste the error. Then run it again. Four rounds is normal. Ten is normal. Getting it right the first time is not a thing that happens to anybody.

So: which list do you actually chase at work? Incomplete files, missing forms, unsigned documents, overdue trainings, unreturned equipment. Same shape, same five steps.